



Great Wall of China

The longest man-made structure ever built, begun by China's first emperor and extended over thousands of years

Created to defend the Chinese empire from various ethnic tribes, including Mongolian nomads, to the north, the Great Wall of China is in fact a series of walls built between the 3rd century BCE and the 17th century CE. Altogether, the walls span 13,170 miles (21,196 km), traversing coastland, deserts, and rugged mountains. The most extensive section is 3,510 miles (5,650 km) long and was built by the Ming dynasty between 1368 and 1644. Around a quarter of the Ming wall consists of natural defenses, such as rivers and mountain ridges, while the rest is made from materials that were available locally, which range from dressed stone and kiln-fired bricks to rammed earth and sun-dried bricks, some held together with sticky rice flour.

Deathly wall

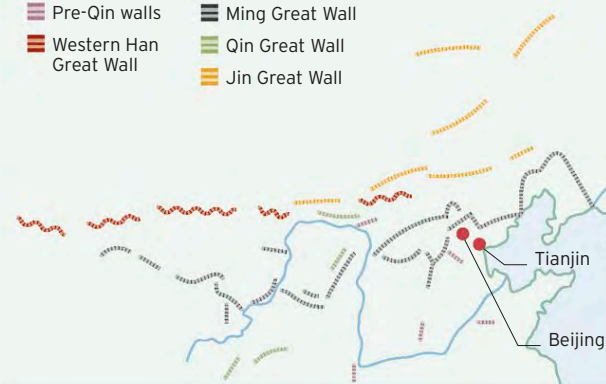
The Great Wall is an average of 21.3 ft (6.5 m) wide at the base and 23–26 ft (7–8 m) high, with some sections reaching 46 ft (14 m). An estimated 1 million of the convicts, peasants, slaves, guards, and citizens employed to build it died in the process, and bones found under parts of the wall suggest that many were buried on site. The wall provided protection

SPANNING THE CENTURIES

The series of walls that comprise the Great Wall of China include the preimperial walls linked together by the first Qin emperor Shihuangdi (r.220–210 BCE). The Han (202 BCE–9 CE) and Jin (1115–1234 CE) dynasties extended the Wall, and the Ming dynasty (1368–1644) built the brick and stonework Wall.

KEY

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|------------------------|-----------------|
| Pre-Qin walls | Ming Great Wall |
| Western Han Great Wall | Qin Great Wall |
| | Jin Great Wall |



from invasion for many centuries, but in 1644, the Manchus broke through and established themselves in Peking (now Beijing), bringing an end to the Ming dynasty's rule. The Great Wall of China was made a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1987. However, sections in the north are still disappearing as a result of desertification and changing land use.

